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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

When All the Content Is Synthetic: The Trust Portfolio

Date & time: Oct. 14, 3:05-3:40 PM
Track: Strategic AI



Joe Pulizzi

Founder, The Tilt

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Session Description

For nearly two decades, marketers have built trust the same way: pick a focus, commit to a platform, publish consistently, and wait. That model still works. The problem is time.

As generative AI floods the internet with low-cost, machine-created content, the window to build an audience that knows, likes, and trusts you is rapidly closing. Attention is increasingly mediated by AI systems that summarize, synthesize, and recommend. In that world, producing "more content" is no longer a viable strategy.

In this session, Joe Pulizzi introduces The Trust Portfolio, a new framework for marketing teams to build credibility faster by diversifying trust across people, not just channels. You'll learn why brand-led audience building has become a high-risk bet, how organizations can activate trusted employees as strategic trust signals, and what guardrails are required to make this work at scale.

When content is infinite, trust is scarce. This session shows how to build it before the window closes.

Key Quote

> *"The opportunity is not that we have fewer human voices; it's that I believe human voices are becoming more valuable."* **- Joe Pulizzi**

Session Summary

Joe Pulizzi, founder of The Tilt, opened by telling the audience that after 26 years of presenting content marketing the same way, he can no longer recommend that model. In its place he introduced the Trust Portfolio, a framework for building credibility through multiple trusted human voices inside an organization rather than through a single brand voice.

He grounded the urgency in the flood of synthetic content. Monthly book uploads to Amazon have jumped from roughly 100,000 to more than 300,000 since November 2022, to the point that Amazon now caps authors at 10 uploads per week per format. He added that 75% of new web pages are partially or fully AI-generated, that an AI influencer earned over $15 million last year, and that AI artists now appear on the Billboard Top 100. His conclusion: human voices are

becoming more valuable, and organizations have roughly nine to 18 months to start these programs.

Pulizzi pointed to data showing that 68% of people question whether what they see is real, and to empathy studies in which customers rated AI agents higher yet still chose humans. He showed the same pattern in the market: the top Spotify podcasts are led by people rather than brands, and The New York Times and Puck now build their newsletters around individual writers.

The core metaphor was investing. Relying on one brand voice is like a 401(k) holding a single stock. Employee content tends to happen in three ways: it just happens (Staples embraced a store employee's viral printer content, while Chick-fil-A pushed back and lost a creator to Shake Shack), it gets enabled with no strategy (which he likened to buying penny stocks), or it is built on purpose. He held up Saturday Night Live as the model, with one powerful brand supporting many human-led franchises, and said marketing leaders should act like Lorne Michaels, the producer.

He recommended a starter pack of three voices, an expert, a storyteller and an advocate, then scaling to nine, 21 and eventually 100. Guardrails include company ownership of the assets, rewards tied to KPIs, clear expectations and an exit plan, so the portfolio can swap voices in and out the way SNL replaces its stars. Before choosing the cast, teams should find their trust gaps, because the first goal is to bring audiences back. He closed by sharing an ungated article, worksheet and field guide.

Key Takeaways

- **Human voices are the scarce asset.** As synthetic content becomes effectively infinite, Pulizzi argued that trusted human voices are becoming more valuable, not less.
- **Diversify trust across people.** Concentrating all content on one brand voice, a CEO or a single creator is as risky as a portfolio holding a single stock.
- **Build it on purpose.** Rather than waiting for employee content to just happen or enabling it with no strategy, design human-led content franchises under one strong brand.
- **Start with three voices.** Launch an expert, a storyteller and an advocate at the same time, learn from those pilots, then scale toward nine, 21 and more.
- **Be the producer, not the creator.** Like Lorne Michaels at SNL, marketing leaders should identify talent, provide editorial help, set guardrails on ownership and rewards, and plan for exits.
- **Find the trust gaps first.** Decide which audiences you most need to earn trust with before picking the cast, since the first goal is simply to bring people back.